Research Abstract

Sattvikabhinaya in Relation to Angika and Vachika Abhinaya: A Critical Textual and Performative Analysis of Kuchipudi with Reference to Textual Traditions

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Keywords: Sattva, Abhinaya, Sattvika abhinaya, Angika abhinaya, Vachika abhinaya, Bhava, Vibhava, Anubhava, Vyabhichari bhava, Rasa theory, Sahrudaya, Nayaka-Nayika bheda, Padam, Javali, Kuchipudi Nrutya Natika

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1. Background and Context

Yato hastas tato drushtih, yato drushtis tato manah,
Yato manas tato bhavo, yato bhavas tato rasah.
(Nandikeshvara, Abhinaya Darpanam)

This verse articulates a flow that begins in the body (hasta), moves through the gaze (drushti) into the mind (manas), crystallises as an emotional state (bhava) and concludes in aesthetic flavour (rasa). The present research locates itself precisely along this flow, investigating **Sattvikabhinaya**, the psycho-physical mode of expression, in its interdependence with **Angikabhinaya** (bodily expression) and **Vachikabhinaya** (verbal/textual-musical expression) within the Kuchipudi tradition.

In Indian aesthetics, dance is a form of communication: every performance aims to carry meaning and emotion from the performer to the audience. Bharata's *Natyashastra* names four modes of *abhinaya* for this purpose: *angika*, *vachika*, *aharya* and *sattvika*. *Angika* provides the movements and gestures of the body (*anga*, *pratyanga*, *upanga*, *hasta*), and *vachika* provides the lyric, music and meaning. *Sattvika* is what brings both of them to life with genuine inner feeling. This research begins from the view that even technically correct *angika* and *vachika* cannot produce **rasa** in the *sahrudaya* (the sensitive spectator) without true *sattvika*. At the same time, *sattvika* does not work on its own; it becomes visible to the audience only through *angika* and *vachika*.

1.1 The Concept of Sattvikabhinaya

The word *sattvikabhinaya* comes from **sattva**. According to the *Natyashastra*, sattva is born from a focused and attentive mind. So sattvikabhinaya is the expression of an emotion that the performer truly feels inside, which then shows naturally on the body. The *Natyashastra* lists eight such **sattvika bhavas**: *stambha* (becoming still or stunned), *sveda* (sweating), *romancha* (hair standing on end), *svarabheda* (change in voice), *vepathu* (trembling), *vaivarnya* (change in complexion), *ashru* (tears) and *pralaya* (fainting).

Theoretically, this study engages with:

- **Bharata's Rasa-sutra** (*vibhavanubhava-vyabhichari-samyogad rasa-nishpattih*), which posits rasa as the outcome of the combination of determinants (*vibhava*), consequents (*anubhava*) and transitory states (*vyabhichari bhava*).
- The idea of the performer's **tanmayibhava** (identification), that is, the capacity to inhabit a character other than oneself while retaining aesthetic distance, thereby enabling the spectator to experience the same emotional state.

2. Objectives of the Study

- To critically examine the textual sources on *sattva*, *abhinaya*, *bhava* and *rasa*.
- To analyse the interrelationship between *sattvika*, *angika* and *vachika* abhinaya.
- To document how characters (*patras*) and their *bhavas* are developed in a Kuchipudi *nrutya natika*.
- To analyse sattvikabhinaya in *padam* and *javali*.
- To create a theoretically grounded, practically applicable resource for young learners.

3. Research Gap and Problem Statement

Although every classical dancer performs in accordance with music and lyric, only some succeed in internalising *bhava* and evoking *rasa*. A significant number of performers render facial expressions mechanically, without conscious awareness of which *bhava* is being portrayed or which *rasa* is intended. Consequently, the performance may lack the transformative quality the tradition calls for. Younger practitioners in particular often express uncertainty regarding the appropriate expression for a given dramatic situation (*sandarbha*).

Existing scholarship tends either to treat the *shastric* theory of rasa in abstraction from practice, or to document repertoire without systematically connecting it to that theory. There is a perceptible **gap in integrated, practice-oriented documentation** that demonstrates, step by step, how a Kuchipudi performer moves from the lyric (*sahitya*) to its meaning, from meaning to *vibhava, anubhava and vyabhichari*, and from these to the generation of rasa in the *rasika*.

> *"Vibhavanubhava vyabhichari samyogad rasa nishpattih"*
> *(Natyashastra, Chapter 6)*

This study seeks to address that gap by offering both a **theoretical framework** and a **performative model** for Sattvikabhinaya in Kuchipudi.

4. Scope of the Study

By bringing all the findings together, the study will offer a clear understanding of how sattvikabhinaya works together with angika and vachika in Kuchipudi, and will give young dancers a practical method to move from the lyric to rasa. The findings may also be useful to teachers, choreographers and researchers. The research is delimited to the following thematic areas:

- Sattvikabhinaya as the central analytical category
- Angika and Vachika abhinaya as its correlative modes
- A Kuchipudi **Nrutya Natika** (dance-drama) as the primary case study
- **Padam** and **Javali** as solo abhinaya centric repertoire
- Classical treatises as the theoretical foundation

5. Research Questions

1. How is sattvikabhinaya described and expressed in the classical texts?
2. How does sattvikabhinaya work together with angika and vachika abhinaya?
3. How are sattva and abhinaya interrelated, and how is rasa generated through them?
4. How do Kuchipudi practitioners understand and convey sattvika in performance?

6. Research Methodology

The study adopts a **qualitative, interdisciplinary research design**, combining **textual analysis, performance analysis** and **fieldwork**.

6.1 Methodological Framework

PHASE I: Textual and Theoretical Inquiry (Shastra)

1. Conceptual study of sattva, abhinaya and the four abhinaya modes (angika, vachika, aharya, sattvika)
2. Analysis of allied concepts
    - Bhava categories: sthayi, vyabhichari, sattvika (49 bhavas)
    - Vibhava (alambana & uddipana) and Anubhava
    - Rasa theory
    - Nayaka-Nayika bheda (incl. ashta-nayika avasthas)
3. Textual analysis across treatises
    - Natyashastra - Bharata
    - Abhinaya Darpanam - Nandikeshvara
    - Sattvikabhinayam - P.S.R. Appa Rao

PHASE II: Correlative Analysis of Abhinaya Modes

4. Angika mapping
    - Hasta, drushti, shiro-bheda, bhru bheda, mukharaga
    - Correlating each gesture to the meaning it delivers
5. Vachika mapping
    - Word-by-word (pada-artha) and contextual (bhavartha) meaning
    - Role of raga, tala, kaku (intonation) and repetition (sanchari)
    - Locating the lyrical cue points that trigger sattvika response
6. Sattvika layering

- Identifying where each of the eight sattvika bhavas can be suggested through angika and vachika means

PHASE III: Repertoire-based Case Studies (Performance Analysis)

7. Data collection
    - Sahitya (lyrics), narrative, music, notation and audio-visual recordings of the selected nrutya natika, padams and javalis
8. Case Study A: Kuchipudi Nrutya Natika
    - Character analysis
    - Tracing bhava transitions across scenes and in between characters
    - Interplay of vachika (dialogue) and angika
    - Identification of dominant (angi) and subsidiary (anga) rasas
9. Case Study B: Padam / Javali
    - Word-by-word meaning of the lyric from pallavi to charanam
    - Identification of nayaka / nayika type and avastha
    - Mapping vibhava -> anubhava -> vyabhichari -> sthayi -> rasa
    - Determining the principal rasa that "floats in the upper layer"
    - Comparative note: padam vs. javali
10. Video-based micro-analysis
    - Frame-by-frame study of recorded performances to observe how sattvika states are rendered through eyes, face and breath

PHASE IV: Ethnographic Fieldwork

11. Semi-structured interviews with Kuchipudi gurus, choreographers and senior performers
    - Their interpretation of shastric theory
    - Pedagogical methods for training sattvika
    - Personal anubhava (lived experience) of rasa on stage
12. Participant observation of classes, rehearsals and lecture-demonstrations

PHASE V: Synthesis and Model Building

13. Formulation of a "Lyric-to-Rasa" analytical model
14. Preparation of a practitioner-oriented guide for young learners

6.2 The Proposed Analytical Model (Lyric-to-Rasa)

The model proposes that the performer moves through the following stages, each one building on the previous:

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Sahitya (the lyric)
  -> Pada-artha (literal meaning)
    -> Bhavartha (contextual / emotional meaning)
      -> Vibhava (alambana: the character, uddipana: the setting)
        -> Bhava (inner state aroused in the performer)
          -> Anubhava (bhava made visible through angika and vachika)
            -> Vyabhichari bhavas (transient states)
              -> Sthayi bhava (dominant emotion)
                -> RASA in the sahrudaya
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6.3 Data Sources

The primary data sources are:

- **Textual:** the classical treatises, namely the Natyashastra, Abhinaya Darpanam and Sattvikabhinayam
- **Performative:** a Kuchipudi nrutya natika and selected padams and javalis
- **Oral:** interviews with gurus, choreographers and performers
- **Videographic:** video recordings of abhinaya pieces

The secondary data sources are:

- Commentaries, translations, scholarly books, journal articles and dissertations related to the topic

7. Limitations

This research has certain limitations. It is restricted to the Kuchipudi style and does not attempt a comparison with other classical dance forms. Aharya abhinaya (costume and make-up) is mentioned only where it supports the other modes and is not studied in detail. The nayaka and nayika types will be referred to where needed, but they will not be studied in depth. Similarly, angika and vachika abhinaya will not be covered completely; only the

aspects that directly support sattvika, such as mukhajabhinaya (facial expression), will be taken up. Because of the time available, only the main nrutya natika and a limited number of padams and javalis can be analysed in depth, and the interviews will mostly be with leading gurus, choreographers and artists. Sattvika bhava is an inner experience, so it cannot be measured fully and some part of its analysis will depend on observation and personal interpretation. The result of sattvikabhinaya is rasa, and this rasa arises in the audience, so it cannot be captured directly on video. What a video can show is the performer's abhinaya and the visible sattvika signs. Finally, some traditional texts may have to be studied through available commentaries.

8. Expected Outcomes and Significance

- A **critical synthesis** of shastric perspectives on Sattvikabhinaya and its relationship to Angika and Vachika.
- A **documented, scene-wise bhava and rasa analysis** of a selected Kuchipudi nrutya natika and padams/javalis.
- A **replicable Lyric-to-Rasa model** that young Kuchipudi practitioners can apply to abhinaya compositions.
- Visual documentation of the sattvika signs that contribute to rasa nishpatti
- A contribution to **dance pedagogy** by bridging the gap between shastra (theory) and prayoga (practice), helping learners understand not only what expression to give, but why and how it generates rasa.

9. Tentative Chapterisation

1. Introduction: background, research problem, objectives and methodology
2. Sattva and Abhinaya in the textual traditions
3. Bhava, Rasa and the Nayaka-Nayika paradigm
4. Angika and Vachika as vehicles of Sattvika
5. Case Study: a Kuchipudi Nrutya Natika
6. Case Study: *Padam* and *Javali*
7. Practitioners' perspectives: fieldwork findings

8. Conclusion: findings, the Lyric-to-Rasa model, and scope for further research

10. Bibliography

- Bharatamuni, *Natyashastra*
- Nandikeshvara, *Abhinaya Darpanam*
- P.S.R. Appa Rao, *Sattvikabhinayam*

These treatises collectively furnish the theoretical foundation for the study of *sattvikabhinaya* and its relationship with *angika* and *vachika* abhinaya.